



**Mother and baby homes (including
pre-1948 Workhouses) and
Magdalene laundries oral history
project**

Interview with HS

Anonymous (HS)

29th October 2018

location of interview redacted

Interviewed by Olivia Dee

Transcribed by Sam Manning

HS spent time in one of the Good Shepherd mother and baby homes in Northern Ireland when she was pregnant in the 1980s. Her powerful testimony involves reflection on the home, her relationship with her parents and the long-term impact of the events surrounding her experiences at this time in her life. HS explains that her family GP was involved in arranging the referral to the Good Shepherds with her mother also involved in attempts to have HS's pregnancy conclude with an adoption. The GP also suggested the alternative of going to live with a family in Dublin to conceal the pregnancy. Keeping her child was not the outcome that her family wanted, but after he was born HS insisted that she was going to bring him home. She describes the long term issues she had with her mother as a result of this. As a single parent, HS received good support from her employer but not all her friends were as open minded and liberal towards her situation. She discusses the challenges of raising her son as a young single mum. HS was 19 years old when she gave birth. She describes carrying out hard physical labour in the Good Shepherd mother and baby home even in the late stages of pregnancy. HS believes that this was about having to repent for her 'sins'. Attendance at chapel involved being accommodated separately from the other mass goers and HS concluded that this was also an indicator of how she was perceived as a sinner. She felt totally isolated during her time with the Good Shepherds and explained that sharing personal details with the other girls and women was not permitted. One of the mothers-to-be in the home at the same time as HS was a 14 year-old girl from the Republic of Ireland who was expecting twins. As was the case with several of our interviewees, HS ruefully

discussed the fact that the father of her baby ‘got away scot-free’: no one has heard of an unmarried father’s home. She discusses the long term psychological impact of the stigma placed on her as a young unmarried mother.

The transcript anonymises individuals and locations to give maximum anonymity to HS. Redactions are indicated by ** on the transcript.

OD: Just for the purposes of the tape, this is Olivia Dee with the Northern Ireland Mother and Baby Home Project and the Magdalene Laundries Project. We are in *name of town redacted* and it is 29th October 2018. And I’m here with an interviewee who’s going to discuss her connection with these institutions. We have a general list of questions that we discuss and obviously you can, if there’s anything that you don’t want to talk about, that’s fine. But what we’re really interested in then is what your connection is with the laundries or the mother and baby home and your experience with that.

HS: OK.

OD: So if you wanted to just tell me in your own words a little bit about that.

HS: Yeah, so it is really just from when I entered it, or how I got there, or how I was directed?

OD: So you could start with what happened to you that made you, kind of, to need to be connected with those institutions in the first place.

HS: Basically it was *date in the 1980s* and I fell pregnant, out of wedlock obviously. And my parents, I hadn’t told my parents until I think I was about

five months pregnant, and they found out really through another relative or whatever. So it was never really discussed openly at home. I was just taken basically into a doctor to make sure that I was physically ok. Just whatever tests needed to be done. And when I was in the doctors I was given the option of either, it was never discussed, as in, you're actually going to have the baby and keep it. The option that was given was that I could have two choices – I could either go to live with a family in Dublin, which to me seemed like 100,000 miles away.

OD: Where were you at this point?

HS: I was in the doctor's surgery at this point. I was living at home with my parents.

OD: In Belfast?

HS: In *name of town redacted*.

OD: In *redacted*.

HS: In *redacted*, yeah. So, the doctor's was in *redacted*. So they just said: "Look, the option is that you can live with a family in Dublin or you can go and live in a convent in *location in Northern Ireland.*" So, to me, *location in Northern Ireland* seemed logistically closer at the time because I'd never actually been to Dublin probably at that age and so that's basically how I got there. I mean, it's really a very blurry time really.

OD: How old were you?

HS: Nineteen. So then, I can really just remember bags being collected and just basically being taken there and brought into the home. *Name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home in Northern Ireland*. Yeah, that's where it was. And, so I was taken there and the head nun there was Sister C. There was another two nuns there, but I can't really, I can remember what they looked like, but I can't really remember their names because we didn't have a lot of interaction. She was the main one really. But there was like a set of rules that were laid down basically when you came in. You were introduced, there was like a sitting room off to the right hand side and you were taken in there with your parents and there was like a basic set of rules applied then at that stage. You weren't allowed to discuss where you'd come from. Everybody obviously knew why you were there, because you were all in the same situation, you were all unmarried mothers. You weren't allowed to have an open discussion with each other either in relation to what your family connections were, where you lived. You weren't allowed to say what your second name was, what your surname was, just in case anybody found out your identity or for whatever reason.

OD: So did they give you a name?

HS: You were allowed to use your first name, and it didn't even have to be your first name. That's just the way it was. So then you were shown upstairs then, you were shown basically a tour with your parents: "This is where you are". Blah, blah, blah. And then there was like dormitories upstairs, like wee narrow single bedroom dormitories. So there was like one, they had wee tiny rooms and there was just like a bed to the left and there was just like a window and a wee small sink and a very narrow wardrobe type thing. And that was basically it.

OD: And that was a room rather than like a cubicle?

HS: It was a cubicle type thing. It was just like a cubicle with a bed and whatever. I can't remember how many there actually was. I think at the time we were there, there was maybe fifteen of us at the time of all ages like really. And was like one bathroom just at the very end then. But the times that you were allowed to use the, you weren't always allowed to have a bath. Those things were limited.

OD: So there were kind of restrictions on...

HS: Yeah, there was restrictions on like washing, because it was the cost of the heating and water and all that sort of stuff or whatever. There was, the daily routine basically was you got up very early in the morning. I think it was around seven o'clock and then obviously had a wash. You came down then for your breakfast. Then there was like, throughout the day then your breakfast was probably at ten o'clock, so you got up and you had to clean your room and do all bits and pieces, whatever. Then you came down and had your breakfast. Then there was cleaning duties to do. Now, the cleaning duties were like, there was like a big marble hall, I always this, there's a story I always tell people. There was a big marble hall, it would probably run the full length of here [HS gestures to the floor of the room in which interview was taking place], and you had, I had to get down to clean that with like a nail brush that size, very heavily pregnant. And you had to, you were always...

OD: Heavily pregnant?

HS: Very heavily pregnant. But you were always made to feel that, you know, you had to repent for your sins basically. That was the general thing of it in that sort of a way.

OD: So it was a punishment?

HS: Pretty much, yeah. That it was just, you know, that you had to do these things and then you had lunch. So you had your lunch. There was never a discussion over the meals. The meals were put down, that was fine. They weren't great, but it was food. And you know they were actually quite strict about you eating it and they would have searched the bins to make sure you didn't waste any food, you didn't throw anything away. So it got to the stage where some of the girls were kind of, sort of scraping it into a bag and you had to sort of bury it somewhere or whatever, you know, that sort of a way.

OD: Was it just kind of standard...

HS: Bog-standard, cheap, whatever, just to get the meals.

OD: Like meat?

HS: You would have had maybe sausages and potatoes and beans and stuff like that, or whatever, you know.

OD: Ok. Something nice and simple.

HS: Standard stuff, you know. A fairly staple diet you probably would have called it. And then you would have had, in the afternoon you would have had your prayers, you were out in the chapel. And whatever, do your prayers or whatever, and again it was all sinners and this sort of carry [on]. That was just the general thing like.

OD: How did that make you feel?

HS: Absolutely just, even now, today like, you would still feel [long pause], you just feel like a lesser person.

OD: Of course.

HS: Yeah, you just feel as if you're just...

OD: I suppose there was such an emphasis on guilt.

HS: Terrible, terrible. And whenever we were going out like, you would have got out maybe once a fortnight or something or once a week or whatever. But you were never allowed to go out in a group, you were only ever allowed to go out as two people. And you were limited as to where you were allowed to go to. And your allowance book would have come in, then you would have gone up to Post Office and cashed the allowance book. I think, from memory, I think the allowance book was about thirty, I think it was thirty-two pound fifteen [pence] a week or a fortnight, I can't remember. And you would have cashed it and straight back down to the home. And you would have handed the money in to Sister C at the office, all of it.

OD: Thirty-two pounds is a lot.

HS: I think, for some reason, it must have been thirty-two pounds a fortnight or something. That figure just sticks in my mind. So you would have given all that money to her and THEN she would have given you back maybe, whatever, money out of it, to get your toiletries and if you wanted a few treats.

OD: Was that your parents paying that, or was that from the state?

HS: That was from the state.

OD: Right.

HS: I never saw my parents. I only saw my parents maybe once a fortnight, maybe once a month if they would have come and took me out for dinner. And straight back then again then. You were limited to the number of phone calls you were allowed to make as well and you weren't allowed anybody connected to you to make phone calls in, obviously, to the thing. We were allowed to make limited phone calls out, but it was just basically to home. You weren't encouraged to ring friends. Nobody was supposed to know you were there basically. It was like a secret society or whatever the case may be.

OD: And if it had been up to you, would you have told people you were there? Or was it put upon you that you should?

HS: It was kind of put upon you that you, you know, again it goes back to the shameful thing that it was a hidden secret and you... I didn't understand at the time. Because it was taken out of my hands by my parents, basically who said: "Look, this is the option you have." At no stage did anybody discuss that I could actually keep my son. The main intention of sending me there that the baby was to be born and it would be taken away, and that was it. And that was the last I would ever see of him.

OD: So was it your understanding then that, you know, when this happened to girls of nineteen, they never kept their babies?

HS: Yeah, pretty much.

OD: But you just felt like this is what happens when you get pregnant?

HS: Yeah, you just get pregnant, you get shoved away in a wee secret society, and somebody takes the baby away and then you go home and act as normal as if nothing happened. And so many of the girls in there, that happened to. It was awful. I bucked the trend when I went in and it was never... My parents never discussed, even when they came to take me out to dinner. They would never have said: "Look, you know, we'll help you out or you can come home or you can take the baby home"; or whatever the case may be. And it was just, and even to this day, it has never ever, ever been discussed. Never been discussed at home. My father's dead now, obviously. My mum's still alive. But even at that... no, never discussed.

OD: Were they very strict Catholics?

HS: Well, my mum would have been. My dad didn't really do religion very much, you know.

OD: Did he just go ahead with...

HS: I don't know, because I've never been able to discuss it like, you know. It just, and then on a Sunday morning you would have been taken, we would have had to wait, Sunday morning we always had to go to Mass. But we would have had to wait till kind of Mass was nearly starting. And you would have been taken up the hall and down through these like metal huts. You know, like old army huts. They were actually old army huts and you would have come out of them at the bottom to the back of the chapel. We were never allowed to sit

down in the chapel. We always had to stand at the back door. We were never allowed into the chapel, because again, everybody would know where you were from and you were sinners and you were unmarried mothers.

OD: This is the chapel up on *location redacted* .

HS: Up on *location redacted*, yeah. So those sort of things would have been the thing that I can remember the most, you know. And just the disconnection. We were literally just taken, put in there for whatever period of time you had to be in there. There was no discussion I had with anybody. I think I met my social worker twice, but again even that was... it was just, it's almost like a blur, it's like a blur. It's like about six months of your life that you just went through the motions of something that somebody else wanted to do. But when it actually came to the end, the reality hit big. When I went in to have my son, he was born on *date redacted*, and again, the trips to the hospital, there was... only I had a cousin that was actually nursing at the time and she lived in *location redacted*. She would have taken me to the hospital, she would have accompanied me. Other than that, you would have been there going on your own or whatever. Do you know what I mean?

OD: At nineteen, that must have been terrifying?

HS: It was awful, and...

OD: And did you, sorry to interrupt, I'm just curious, did you have a concept of what was going to happen? Did you understand pregnancy?

HS: Not really.

OD: No, I don't think I would have done.

HS: It was just something that happened. It wasn't discussed, you were just in the convent. Medically, they just did the things they had to do and you just... nobody, you hadn't got anybody to talk to about it. Do you know what I mean? Your fears or whatever. It was just go through the motions, get in, and then, I'll always, whenever *son's name redacted* was born, he was born at five to ten at night. And they came straight away and took him away. Took him away. I never seen him for two days. Never seen him until, and I didn't know, that was the thing, because when he was taken away, whenever I was in the home, the rule of thumb was that, basically, that was why everybody was there. The babies were born, they were taken away. Six weeks later, you'd come back to the home and sign the papers and you'd never see the babies again. That was the understanding. That was the bits and pieces we could talk about. Yeah know, that was only in residence and that was only like what we were kind of hearing. Once the girls went out like when I went to the hospital and had the baby, you were never allowed back to the convent again. So you couldn't have that conversation with the girls that were there.

OD: So they wouldn't really understand?

HS: We as residents wouldn't have understood what those girls went though, left to have their babies and then never seeing them again, ever. There was only, the reason why I know there was two girls. There was a girl called *redacted* and I can't remember what you call the other girl, but I remember seeing them or hearing of them coming in just to sign the papers, just to hand the babies over and that was it. They had no contact whatsoever after that. That was done and dusted.

OD: And you just thought that was normal?

HS: Well this is the process that we understood we had to follow, you know. And when *son's name redacted* was taken away, it was actually, it was actually on the Saturday. He was born on Friday night and he was taken away obviously and then my parents. It was actually the Saturday afternoon my dad came down with his brother and I think my mum was there. I can't actually remember my mum; that's so strange like I can't remember my mum being there. But I remember sitting there and I had no baby and I was on a ward with four other women and they all had babies and stuff. One of the nurses came in obviously to check on everybody and said: "Would you like to see the baby?" And I looked at her, and I didn't know whether I was allowed to, I didn't know. I still didn't know what I was doing. No idea what I was doing.

OD: Of course.

HS: To me it was taken out of my hands, it was out of my control. And I said: "Yes, I'd love to see him" and then went down to the nursery. So my mother must have been there. And, again, but there was no discussion. And that was literally it, like five minutes in the nursery that was it. And the baby, as far as they were concerned, whatever arrangement was made between the convent and them, I don't know any of that. So I don't know. Obviously somebody has filled in paperwork or had a discussion between the doctor, my parents, the convent, the hospital. Because for them to take him away and not discuss any of this with me, their intention... I don't even know what the intention was when I left the hospital. Was he going to an adoptive mother for six weeks before the papers were signed? I don't know any of the answers to that because I took him home.

OD: So you didn't...

HS: Because I took him home, I bucked the trend. And the Sunday, I just, I don't know what and I just rang home, and I had to borrow the money to make the phone call, and there was a lady called *name redacted*. This was [the 1980s] like, but I'll never forget her. And I said: “*name redacted*, would you have a couple of 10p's for the phone?” And I just lifted the phone and I said: “Look, I'm taking this baby home, whether you like it or you don't.” And that was it. And then everything else after that was like a spiral, do you know? Just, I don't know whether they were waiting for me to say that or again it was never discussed and... either way I was taking him home. And there was nobody who was going to stop me. Nobody was going to stop me and I took him. And that's...

OD: What's his name?

HS: *Son's name redacted*, yeah, but again he doesn't know any of this. Well he doesn't know any of the convent stuff. Again, because it was never discussed. It was the whole shame of it. Like even now, you see when these things come out and people are watching films and all going “ah, have you seen that film? Why don't you watch that film?” and “Why don't you read this book?” What would I want to read those books for? You know.

OD: Because you're living that.

HS: I'm living it, you know. It might not have been the worst that some people put up with, but it was the humiliation of it. It's the fact that, like we didn't do any wrong, anymore wrong than anybody else did.

OD: No, not at all.

HS: But it was just the way they made you feel, the humiliation. Even today like it still has that, you know, I don't know what it is, you just don't feel confident in groups of people. Like I would keep myself to myself, you know.

OD: Of course. And do you think that, do you think that...

HS: You never feel you're good enough.

OD: Why do you think that is?

HS: Because you were constantly told you were, you know.

OD: It sounds really, really tough.

HS: It wasn't the easiest life, you know. And you try, you try, you try, you try. And I mean I strive, I try and I work seven days a week because there's a drive in there. Because I am as good as the next person.

OD: Absolutely. What was the process of bringing him home like? Was it difficult with the nuns to have him taken out? Was there assistance?

HS: I don't even, I don't even really recall. I only recall going back probably to the convent to collect the few bits and pieces that I had left there. Now all be it... and I actually, I actually what I did was I gave, there was a wee girl, she was fourteen. Fourteen, and she was expecting twins. And she came in, she came in from the south, but she came in with absolutely nothing. No clothes, nothing. Nobody ever came to see her either and I gave her whatever bits I had. Whatever bits of money and stuff. There was actually a girl there as well that I

recognised. She was also from *name of town redacted*. But again we never had that open discussion, we never had a conversation.

OD: Oh my gosh!

HS: You just couldn't, you couldn't. Because you always had that fear that you were going to get thrown out and where were you going to go, do you know?

OD: That's really interesting. That's really interesting because you read stories of some women who try and run away and they're brought back. But I always wondered whether there was, was there a fear of, if I'm kicked out of here, where do I go? And that's really interesting.

HS: Yeah, you know, I think that's a thing as well in my life. I have always got this drive in me to make sure that I'll always have a roof over my head and my children will always have a roof over their head because when you're faced with that, it's not a decision like, when you're faced with that... How could I put it? Somebody's saying; right, you've been cut out of your home at the most vulnerable time of your life and nowhere to go. It's tough like.

OD: Not fully understanding...

HS: No. What's going on like.

OD: Did you have any kind of, with the father, did you ever see him again?

HS: He went to *overseas location*. Oh, like *son's name redacted* met his dad and all. And that was another like... he didn't see him for eighteen years. Well that was again an arrangement my parents had made, whatever.

OD: So they sent him?

HS: Just everything was like, they did it.

OD: Do you think they paid him, or...

HS: No, no, no. I think it maybe came along more along the lines of a threat to be honest [laughs]. But yeah, he went to *overseas location* then and like he's still there now. But *son's name redacted* met him when he was eighteen and stuff like that and whatever.

OD: How did that go?

HS: It went really well between the two of them. And like * son's name redacted* suffers too because he's, you know, probably I thought I was doing the best thing by not by turning between two people. And I don't know, it's just difficult, you know.

OD: Well I think from what it sounds like, you had very little choice in it anyway.

HS: I didn't have any choice like.

OD: And I think also, when you go through something like that, I mean I can't imagine that's the first thing in your mind, to track down...

HS: No.

OD: No, I imagine you just want to focus on...

HS: And make sure that he's ok. I mean, I went back to work then. As soon as I came out I went back to work and I've worked ever since like, you know.

OD: So where were you working? You don't have to say the place, but what kind of job were you doing?

HS: I was doing a *nature of job redacted*.

OD: Ah, ok.

HS: And they were very good, because they said...

OD: And they let you go back?

HS: They let me go back. They said to me before I left: "Look, we know your situation or whatever. You go and do, you know, whatever you need to do and whenever you're ready to come back to work the job's still here for you."
Which was like...

OD: Fantastic.

HS: Fantastic like, you know.

OD: So what did you do around things like childcare and stuff? Did your parents help, or did your parents refuse to acknowledge or?

HS: Well, no I was living at home with them. But again that was down to me. I paid, I earned twenty-five pound a week and I paid it all out to a childminder, a lady that lived down beside us. My mum, she worked part-time and she would have maybe collected him then from the childminder until I came home from work. Well I worked shift work because, you know, some night I wouldn't be home maybe until three o'clock in the morning or whatever. And, you know, so obviously I needed and I had other brothers and sisters there as well, so you know.

OD: What was it like with you family after that? Did you have any resentment about what they'd done, or any anger? Or was it quite easy to go back into that?

HS: Well my family would have been quite young and again, it has never been discussed. It has never been discussed. It has never been brought up in conversation. A couple of times my mother might have said... my mother treated my son's father like a hero whenever she met him. That's the difficult part that I can't understand. She just brought him in with open arms, treated him like a complete hero, as if he was just the most brilliant person in the world and not a thought did she give for my feelings, emotions. It's a really difficult one to understand.

OD: So there's a real double standard there between the women...

HS: Absolutely.

OD: Even though it took both of you to... yeah.

HS: You know, so.

OD: That must be really difficult.

HS: You just can't find words for it, you know. I just can't understand, you know, where she's coming from and, you know, the way that she's done. Like, he's been treated like a hero, but I'm still treated like, my mother still treats me like down here like. You know, you're not...

OD: What's her relationship like with your son?

HS: Great. Great, you know.

OD: Do you have any resentment over that?

HS: Towards my parents?

OD: Yeah.

HS: Well, I've never actually, I've never challenged them. I've never said anything. I'm probably just hurt, and you know, just I don't think I ever will. I probably deep down probably do have. I mean if I spoke to maybe a psychologist or something, they'd probably say: "Yes, you've deep-rooted whatever." You know, but I've never done that either. So I just let go. I just let it go. Whatever it is, it is. I can't change what happened, I can only try and make the best of what's left. That's all I can do, you know. At the end of the day, if I work hard enough and my kids are safe and they've got a roof over their head. And I'll always be here for them. Always be here.

OD: I can see that.

HS: My mother has a lot to answer to.

OD: And did anything like this ever happen with any of your siblings?

HS: My sister, she got, she was pregnant then. And then she, the guy that she got pregnant to, they're actually married now. But my dad set them up in a house and stuff like that, so yeah.

OD: Do you think that's because they got married?

HS: Well they didn't get married for years like. They didn't get married... they didn't get married, like get pregnant and then get married, arranged the wedding or anything. They set up the house for them to let them live together or whatever.

OD: And was there a massive time difference. Did this happen decades apart or...

HS: No.... A couple of years, two years maybe.

OD: So maybe they learned, they learned, that's an awful lesson to learn...

HS: Or maybe they preferred the fella that she was actually involved with. He was from quite an affluent family. So that might have had something to do with it as well. So who knows? Who knows what the decisions were, you know.

OD: You've done amazingly well to, kind of, come to terms with that. It must have been hard.

HS: Yeah. I probably haven't if the truth be told, come to terms with it totally. But I put a brave face on it.

OD: And who can you talk to about this? Who do you...

HS: I don't talk to anybody about this.

OD: Even partners or...

HS: Never, because it's just, you just feel ashamed and especially with more of the stuff that's coming out in the papers and about all the laundries and about... you know, I don't want people feeling sorry for me. I don't want people, do you know what I mean?

OD: Yeah.

HS: It's a thing that's happened. It's a time of my life that I'll never get back and it still haunts me. It always will. You'll always feel that you're a lesser person than other people. That wee ghost back here, someone will always say... you think you're doing so well and then all of a sudden this wee ghost raised its head and it pulls you back from maybe doing something then you're able to do. And it's just a confidence thing, it pulls you back to say "I'm not good enough to do it. I'm not good enough to be in their company." You know, it's always there in your subconscious.

OD: Which I can completely understand. Especially, I suppose, that pressure to, I don't know... If someone's telling you that you're a sinner and someone's telling you that you're guilty and someone's telling you that you're shameful...

HS: And everything has to be kept as a secret.

OD: Yeah, and the secretive nature of...

HS: And don't talk to anybody about it, and don't let them know that you're here, and you can't talk to each other...

OD: Even not to be able to talk to the people who are in the same situation as you. That also must be very difficult.

HS: Yeah, exactly.

OD: Because they're probably the few people who can really understand.

HS: And relate to what's going on, and you know. You're not allowed to swap details and you can't contact each other when you get out. It all has to be brushed under the carpet and just, we'll do what we have to do, we'll do whatever paperwork has to be involved, we'll take away the sin, we'll sort it all out and you just go home and live a normal life. It doesn't happen like that. Like life's just not like that, you know.

OD: And I imagine it made you feel very alone.

HS: Very isolated.

OD: When actually it happens to so many people.

HS: Yeah.

OD: Oh, it's just, yeah, it must have been tough.

HS: And I remember years after that, and I worked round in an *occupational detail redacted* round the street there. And it was just such a surreal experience. But there was a couple, a wee couple who used to come in there. And they were from *location redacted*. And they would have been a really nice wee couple who come And I remember the wife came in and then was talking or whatever. And she talked about, they were retired at that stage, and they had bought houses ... and they were doing a B&B out of it. And whatever way the conversation, I don't know how the conversation struck up, but she told me that her eldest daughter was a baby that she got from *mother and baby home where HS was sent*.

OD: Oh wow.

HS: And I looked at her and I said "What?" She said, "yeah", she said "we adopted a child from *mother and baby home where HS was sent*. And I said "*asked question about location*". She says "Yeah, do you know it?" I says "I do indeed." And that was, I just couldn't and I thought that could have been anybody's child. It could have been mine, it could have been anybody's. Now, the child couldn't have went to better parents, but I often wondered if they couldn't have children. So I often wondered in what circumstances, or how, or the parents of that wee baby, do they know where the child is? In what circumstances did they get the baby? You know, those sort of things. I don't know the answers to any of those questions. I'm sure they're questions that people have, you know.

OD: Yeah, I mean I can't even imagine how, I suppose you never know when something like that's going to come up, do you? You've got to be, kind of, guarded.

HS: Aware.

OD: And I suppose obviously, however wonderful the parents are, you still think about those girls in the convent.

HS: Yeah, it's the secrecy behind it all. You know and it's what... I mean I know that some of the stories are just horrendous like, but it's the secrecy of it all. You know, where do the babies go? And then, you know, you never... It's just that wee pocket of people that's there. You come in, you get the tour, everything's top secret, you don't exchange names, you don't have to use your own name, you never discuss family, you never tell them where you're from, you're limited to the phone calls you can make, absolutely no visitors coming in other than your parents, they don't even come in. And there was a code for the bell at the front door as well. Like there would have been a certain number of rings if you were coming back. You might have had to ring the bell three successive times and they would have known it was a resident. If it was a stranger obviously coming, they would ring the doorbell as normal or whatever.

OD: Why do you think they did that?

HS: Don't know.

OD: It's just to sort of prepare, maybe. Interesting. It's those little details I think that are so interesting, how they created... Can I ask a couple of questions?

HS: You can ask me as many questions as you like, yeah.

OD: I'm really interested. So, obviously we've got kind of the overview. I'd love to ask you just a couple more details. How was your family life prior to this happening? I mean, did you ever talk about the home? Did you ever talk about, you know, gossip about other girls that might have got in that situation? Did you have an awareness that that home even existed?

HS: No.

OD: Because I know in small communities sometimes there's sort of: "oh, we don't talk about that place." So I'm just wondering, so you had no awareness?

HS: No, never. I had no inclination of it at all.

OD: So when, I know you said you're not quite sure how you ended up sort of going there. But I'm assuming your mother would have contacted either a social worker or a priest.

HS: They must have, they must have done. It was my family doctor told me when I went in for my first appointment. It was the family doctor told me, give me the options.

OD: And that was either go and stay with family or...

HS: In Dublin.

OD: Which is, must have been terrifying.

HS: A family. I didn't know who they were. It was obviously...

OD: Oh, a family.

HS: A family. No, no, this was a family that obviously took in...

OD: That's even scarier.

HS: Yeah.

OD: So your GP was the one who gave you the options.

HS: Yeah.

OD: And how was your GP with you. Kind, or...

HS: He was fine, he was nice and he was just...

OD: He must have seen it.

HS: Yeah, he may have probably have seen it more than... Yeah.

OD: And then were you taken straight from there? Did your parents drive you?

HS: Yeah, they must have. Just those wee bits are blurry, I'm assuming they did, with a bag and a few bits of possessions in it. And I think I went in *month redacted*. I think it was *month redacted*.

OD: And this was nineteen?

HS: *Year redacted*. It's not even that long ago. I know it's *number redacted* years ago, but it's...

OD: Oh no, I mean it's just before I was born.

HS: Come on, it's not 1912 or anything like.

OD: No. And I think that really surprises people, really surprises people

HS: What? Do you think?

OD: People often think we're talking about twenties, thirties.

HS: 1920s, 1930s, yeah.

OD: No, *year redacted* is... wow. Ok so you turn up and they show you this cubicle and you sort of...

HS: Put your bag in, get the tour of the place. And then there was the laundry room out the back and whatever. The funny thing was, and it's just wee funny things come up, you weren't really allowed to go outside to hang your washing out.

OD: Right, ok.

HS: I never figured that one out. You know, there was like a garden outside, but we were never allowed to go and sit in the garden. Like, there was like a garden area out the back. There was a washing line there and there was occasions you

would have seen stuff hung on the line, but we were never allowed to. Like you would have thought on a nice day, they would have opened the doors and let you go out and sit, like pull out a chair or something and you could sit outside. We were never allowed to sit outside.

OD: Was it visible to the road? Was that why?

HS: No. It was an enclosed rear garden, grass area.

OD: Was it just too nice? Was it not part of the treatment? It just sounds like a punishment again.

HS: I don't know.

OD: Interesting. So I've been to *mother and baby home where HS was sent*, so I'm just thinking of the layout.

HS: You know when you go down the hall, there's like a marble hallway and there's like the sitting room on the left. And then there's like the wee... Sister C's office and then there's like a wee laundry room. At the very, very back. But when you're in the living room, there was like sofas and whatever else there, but there's like a glass window. There was like a garden area out there with a washing line there.

OD: It must have changed.

HS: This is my memory. This is my memories of it like.

OD: No, I mean, like I said it's changed so much.

HS: And then there was like, on the other side there was like the marble hallway, and then there was like the glass windows the whole way up the hallway. To the left, you went down then, there was like the wee oratory, the wee chapel, the wee small chapel. And then further on past that I think that's where you had to go through the tin huts to get to the back of the chapel.

OD: And so on your first...

HS: The staircase upstairs then, the spiral staircase. We were upstairs. Yeah, there was like wee dormitory type things. And there's the bathroom just at the top of the stairs from memory. Yeah, I think.

OD: Wow.

HS: And then there was like, when you came down the stairs, when you come in through the front door, there's like the hallway. You come in through the front door, the kitchen was to the left. There was a phone box to the left. And then, yeah because you could see the outside from the dining area as well I think. And then, yeah when you come down the hallway then there was the wee sitting room to the right where people would have come in. And that's where you would have met your social worker or whatever.

OD: So were you put to work immediately?

HS: Well as soon as you came in you had your chores. That was it. Like there was no faffing about, no. Like this is why you're here. You're here and you pretty much have to pay your way, repent, whatever you have to do.

OD: Even though you were also paying for your board through state...

HS: I'm sure we didn't really comprehend. We didn't know that we were going in and we got an allowance book and we were told: 'Yes, there's the Post Office. Go up and sign it off. Sign the thing, get your money and come back and give it to us. And we'll give you a couple of pound back then to keep yourselves going.'

OD: So how pregnant were you when you arrived?

HS: I was, when I went there I was probably about seven months pregnant.

OD: Wow.

HS: Six-and-a-half, seven months pregnant.

OD: So had you managed to hide it up until that point? That's amazing. Did you not show much, or did you...

HS: I just, you learned to hide. Yeah, you learned to hide it.

OD: And did you really understand what you were hiding?

HS: Not really.

OD: Right, that's what I... because I think...

HS: Because then your friends kind of sort of drift of too because they don't want to be associated with you. Do you know, it's like oh God we can't be seen with her type thing.

OD: So you didn't talk to anyone. So all you knew was that you were, something was not right, but you weren't entirely sure what was going to happen.

HS: Yeah, and that was it. And then everybody just disappears and leaves you. And then you're on your own. And then you're pushed down the road into a convent.

OD: And then you're cleaning the floors at seven months...

HS: And then whatever else you have to do when you're down in there, washing and ironing and whatever.

OD: So there was no leniency for the time, for the...

HR: Oh no. No, for anybody.

OD: So it didn't get easier when it was...

HR: No, no.

OD: It's dangerous, surely.

HR: You just get in, you have your chores to do. This is it, you know.

OD: Did anyone ever, kind of, have any complications while you were there, from that kind of work?

HR: Not that I, not I can remember, not that I'm aware of.

OD: Your back must have hurt awful.

HR: I think that's what probably drives me today. Most people say to me "where, why do you not stop, where do you get your energy from?" You know. I just push through things and I think it's mentally back here somewhere where it was the determination, you'll not break me. That sort of a thing.

OD: Yeah, I think that's incredible and so rare as well. It's so rare to hear that kind of, I don't I think it's...

HR: Maybe it's stubbornness. Maybe it's not a good, healthy thing. But it's the thing that made me survive.

OD: But you got your son, yeah.

HR: Survival, you know.

OD: So, we're talking kind of things like cleaning floors. I mean probably cleaning floors probably more than is necessary.

HR: Cleaning floors would have been ok with a mop bucket and a mop. But when you're down on your flipping hands and knees doing it with a nail brush and a fucking cloth, it's a different story like.

OD: Oh God! Your back. What were the nun's like? Were they...

HR: Sister C you didn't really see an awful lot of. She would have been in the office, she would have collected the money. If there was an issue or something, she would have come out and just, if there was like somebody...

OD: *inaudible*

HR: Yeah, and there was another nun, and God forgive me for saying it, there was another tall nun. She was actually quite nice, but we didn't see an awful lot of her at all. She was quite pleasant. They didn't have time to spend with you. They were just firing out the orders. That was it. They were quite dictators-ship type thing. But this other wee nun, she had a funny, like *physical characteristic redacted*. She was real wicked. Real just, her face told it all.

OD: Scary?

HS: Oh, she wasn't nice at all, yeah. And she was real wicked and, you know, you kind of tried to make conversation with her and she was having none of it. And she would come out, barked at you and shouted at you. Real cross, real wicked.

OD: What kind of things did they... So I think, because when you read some people's accounts of it, it wasn't, like there was no kind of physical violence of any kind but...

HS: It was emotional and...

OD: That's what they say ...So they're trying to kind of... do you think it was a conscious thing to make you feel worse?

HS: Oh, inadequate certainly and just you are, that was it.

OD: And that was the punishment.

HS: Yeah, and they were very good at it. Very good at it. I remember there was one girl called *name redacted*, if that was her real name. But God help her. I used to feel so sorry for her because, I think she was maybe a wee bit older than me, but she obviously had, she wasn't coping very well. But she would have went out, and absolutely no alcohol was allowed, but that's obviously understandable for health reasons and stuff. But poor *redacted* used to come in and she would have, I think maybe she had a wee drink problem or whatever because she used to maybe sneak around. Maybe she'd sneak out and get a wee drink or whatever. But she used to come in on her visitation weekends or whatever and she'd come in with a face flying. You knew she had drink, but she, now, got herself into trouble a few times. So I don't actually know, you know.

OD: Well I suppose if you have a problem with drink before you go in and nothing's being done to help it...

HS: That's it exactly, you know. So would have been the only one really. But most of the girls that were there, were there with the intention of leaving their baby behind. I think of the group that I was in, I think I was the only one. And again, until he was born, I'm sure that's what was assumed by the other girls.

OD: So when you saw him for the first time, that wasn't when he was born, that was a couple of days later.

HS: It was the Saturday. No, no, he was just taken away straight away.

OD: So no contact?

HS: No.

OD: Oh, that's tough.

HS: Until the Saturday, and even on the Saturday it was literally just to show my parents and he was in the wee cot. And he was lying like this here. He was lying like with his wee fists up like this here. And I just looked in and like, it was funny, it was funny because, it was just like it was a baby lying there, do you know what I mean? And there was no facial expression from my parents at all. And I don't even know what was discussed when they went home, because they literally just left after that.

OD: And would that have been their first grandchild?

HS: Yes, yep.

OD: That's amazing.

HS: Yeah.

OD: So you went, and I know probably this is quite blurry, but when you saw him, and from that point you were like that's mine. That's my child.

HS: And he's coming home.

OD: So when did you bring him home?

HS: On the, well I rang them on the Sunday and I think I was probably. The day I brought him home. The date I brought him home was the *date redacted*. He was born on the *redacted* and I brought him home on the *redacted*. I'll never forget that.

OD: So you brought him home...

HS: On the *dated and year redacted*.

OD: And what was that like?

HS: It was really strange, because I always remember when I was coming up... The journey home wasn't really memorable, but the thing I do remember was when I was coming up to go round the corner to my own parents' house. There's like a place called the *redacted* and they would have youth centres and stuff in it. But, it's weird things stick out in your mind, about how long the grass was. And the grass needed cut. And that was the only memory of that whole journey home was how long the grass was.

OD: It's weird the way that happens, isn't it?

HS: Yeah, and it was summertime and it was all dried and it looked like hay and...

OD: And how soon did you go back to work?

HS: *month redacted* Probably a couple of weeks later, as soon as I got a babysitter organised. I always remember too, well I had to go back to work because I... Different people had said “oh, the social services, you fill in the forms and you’ll get all sorts of money” and blah, blah, blah and whatever. So, the people came down from the social services and they came to inspect the room, the wardrobes, to see what clothes I had.

OD: Right.

HS: And I shared a room with my two other sisters. And obviously your woman looked in the wardrobe and thought right, well there’s no need here for money.

OD: Oh no.

HS: And went home and I always remember, always remember, and again I think this is a driving force, there was a letter came in the post with a cheque attached to it. And the letter said, it was a piece of paper and it said: ‘one pair of slacks’. I was looking for money to help me back to work for clothes. Because obviously your clothes that you wore beforehand didn’t fit you anymore, and I had no money to buy clothes to go to work, and that’s what I was looking for. One pair of slacks – thirteen pound. That was it. That was all I got and I thought you, well, you can take your thirteen pounds and put it where the sun doesn’t shine! I’ll not ask you for any more. And I’ve never asked, to this day, touch wood. No help, no financial help, no. No maintenance, nothing.

OD: Wow, and you’re the kind of person that it’s probably designed for as well. I mean, wow, that’s tough.

HS: You do like whenever you're faced with it you have to have glide on under it or...

OD: So...

HS: Doesn't make it easy like. There's times whenever you have really dark days like.

OD: Of course. So you went back to work, paid for a childminder basically using all your wages. At what point did you manage to move out?

HS: *son's name redacted* was nine.

OD: Wow, so you had to stay for nine years.

HS: He was nine.

OD: Was that tough?

HS: It was just, you got into a routine really, you know. I had to go to work. I needed their support because if, I couldn't have managed if I was out. And I got married and that wasn't a great marriage either like. That was a horrendous thirteen years, but anyway sure look...

OD: So you got married when you left after nine years?

HS: Yeah.

OD: And it wasn't great?

HS: It wasn't great, no. But anyway, so...

OD: Do you think your experience either made you look for someone who wasn't right for you? Or do you think it was...

HS: probably just, no the experience probably made me choose somebody because I probably thought I wasn't good enough. Again, just picked...

OD: That's really understandable.

HS: That's, you know, until I kind of, sort of realised that I am a bit better than this. I'm on my own now like. Well I do have, not a partner as such, but you know...

OD: A friend.

HS: A friend, yeah. And he's very good. And he doesn't, you know, he lives way down in the country. Like we don't live together or anything, you know. But...

OD: So you, did you have any more children?

HS: One daughter, *name redacted*.

OD: Oh, congratulations. That's amazing. So she's what, nine years younger, a few years younger.

HS: She's *age redacted*. There's eleven years between the two of them.

OD: Ok, great, and do they get on?

HS: Yeah, they do. I mean *son's name redacted* lives now in *town redacted*.

OD: Oh right, ok.

HS: And she lives at home with me. So she is doing her last year in university, so...

OD: Where does she go?

HS: And they're both doing very well for each other. He's doing very well work wise. And yeah, so...

OD: So you obviously did it really well.

HS: I hope I did, you know. So, yeah, she's in *name of university redacted*. She's finishing.

OD: *redacted*

HS: Well, there you go. So she's doing *name of University course redacted*, so she'll be finished now in May.

OD: Wow. That's really good, that's amazing.

HS: Yeah, so.

OD: It always really great when someone's had that kind of start and they feel, I don't know, there's emotion bound up within that, and you've clearly just done such an amazing job with your own kids.

HS: You have to. You see so many other people out there that just weren't strong enough to get through it and it is not easy. It really isn't easy. It's easier to give up. It's easier to give up. But for some mental thing, or whatever goes on in my head once, whether it's a good thing or a bad thing, it's hard, it's tough. It's really tough and you do get really dark days. With, like *name of daughter redacted* would know my dark days are coming again. I maybe have a couple of days a month and it really just kind of, you know just shut off from everybody. Don't answer phones, you know. Keep working like, I wouldn't stop working, but you just don't want the emotional attachment to even speak to people.

OD: Yeah, understandably.

HS: And that's really...

OD: And have you ever talked to anyone about that?

HS: Not really. Because I just, well I did actually. I went to a guy there a couple of months back for anxiety and stuff like that. And went to that Cognitive Behavioural Therapist or whatever and tried that for a wee while and it kind of, he was kind of sort of, I don't know what way he was doing. He was going on about the way I was sitting and the way I was talking and trying to slow the

speeds of my thought. I can't be doing with this, paying your money to be doing this. And I just give it up then. I just thought, you know, I'll deal with it myself.

OD: Yeah, yeah, okay. I'm so interested in your transformation. It's amazing. Just such a tough start, to have gone through that. So, let me just think if there's anything else that I'd really like to ask. Oh, the other thing, yes, so obviously you were at *mother and baby home where HS was sent*. Did you have any interaction with the laundry while you were there and the women that were in the laundry? Or had that finished by the time you were there?¹

HS: That had actually finished. We just had the laundry room down the back.

OD: But there was no one working?

HS: There was no... we did our own laundry. We just did our own bits and pieces. But not to my knowledge at that stage...

OD: I think it had ended. Ok, great. I'll check, because some of the earlier testimonies talk about that. But that would have been sort of mid-seventies. And obviously you're sort of after that.

HS: Yeah.

OD: Do you know what happened to... well obviously actually you have an interesting perspective because you met someone who actually adopted from *mother and baby to which HS was sent*.

¹ The adjacent laundry (linked to the St Mary's home on the same convent site) had closed by that point.

HS: Yeah.

OD: But do you have any understanding of where the majority of the babies were going? There was no discussion.

HS: You never, you weren't allowed to discuss how far on your pregnancy was, what your plans were....

OD: So girls would just disappear?

HS: Just disappear. As we said, as soon as the baby was born, you literally went out, you might, they would have come back. I saw one or two of them come back. Now obviously, they were at different stages of pregnancy, you could have been there whenever the other ones had gone away and come back. But I do remember two of them coming back and what I was told was that they were back to sign the adoption papers. They literally had the baby, the baby was taken away. Six weeks later, you came back to sign the papers and that was it. And that was it. And in my head I was kind of thinking, I think at one stage I kind of panicked and I thought 'what am I going to do? Six weeks – I can't do this, I can't do this'. And nobody wanted, I couldn't talk to anybody. I couldn't talk to my parents about it because they just... I didn't know who to talk to.

OD: And did the nuns try and talk you out of it?

HS: They never mentioned it. It was never discussed.

OD: So you just...

HS: As far as they were concerned I was in to do as I was told. I wasn't to challenge anything or challenge anybody. And they were obviously having this discussion with my parents or somebody. Nobody was having the conversations with me at all. I was just the carrier of a baby that somebody was going to take away and do whatever they wanted with.

OD: But they still would have expected you to sign, not your parents?

HS: I would have had to sign the papers, yeah.

OD: Yeah, okay.

HS: But again that wasn't discussed.

OD: But then if you're not discussing what you're signing, then it's not really, it doesn't feel valid, does it?

HS: Yeah, even when I went in to have *son's name redacted*, nobody said to me "right, this is what you're going to do, this is what's going to happen."

OD: So was labour scary? It must have been terrifying.

HS: Well, I was on my own for a start.

OD: It's scary enough anyway. So, you know, obviously things like your waters breaking and stuff must have been...

HS: Well, they had to take me in because *son's name redacted* was two weeks, he was two weeks late. It went over two weeks and they had to take me in and they had to do all that.

OD: So they induced?

HS: They induced the labour and stuff like that and whatever. So I think I went in at half-three in the afternoon. So like literally, you just had your wee bag and away you went. And again, only my cousin was there. She took me in, in through the doors: "off you go". That was it.

OD: And did you have, did you have sort a normal labour or did you have caesarean?

HS: No. I hadn't got a caesarean, no. Forceps delivery it was, yeah.

OD: Oh, you poor thing.

HS: Look, it didn't mean anything to me at the time. It was just a whole new thing going on.

OD: And did you have pain relief?

HS: Yeah, they gave me an epidural.

OD: Ok, good.

HS: Yeah, so yeah, I remember that.

OD: And what was your treatment like when you were there?

HS: In the hospital?

OD: How did the doctors and nurses treat you?

HS: Look, I didn't know whether it was good or bad treatment. But it was just the fact that I was there. The whole thing to me is just, like, for a timescale, it's like a six-month thing. This is what you do, you just go through the motions. There's people there. They pick all the steps or whatever. There's no kindness as such. There's no emotion attached to it. It's a function, it's a function.

OD: So was this *name of hospital* or was this ...

HS: No, it was *name of hospital*, yeah. And it just opened that year ... I think it's [the ward] closed now actually. So yeah, it was *name of hospital ward*.

OD: So did you have any, when you were in the home, did you have regular medical examinations? Did the nuns, were the nuns trained midwives or anything?

HS: I don't know. I think they might have been. But I obviously never had to call on their services or anything. Just had the routine...

OD: So you never had examinations?

HS: No, no just had the routine hospital appointment. That was it.

OD: So I'm just wondering when you're doing, kind of, what's, you know for a seven-month old... pregnant woman quite heavy labour. You'd think that there would perhaps be more of a check-up or more of a making sure that you're ok.

HS: No blood pressure checks, nothing. Nothing. Just whatever routine appointments were there that came in, you went for them. You got the bus in.

OD: So they'd come to you, or would you go to the hospital for those?

HS: No, I think we, probably, whenever we got there, you probably had a hospital appointment, obviously to get you registered and stuff. They obviously had that all sewn up and tied up and whatever. And you went for your, and then you would have had your wee appointment card for your next appointment. And I'm sure if anything ever happened in-between times, they would have been taken care of, yeah.

OD: But there was no kind of like, like midwife check-ups or kind of examinations or...

HS: Nothing.

OD: So we've talked a bit about this kind of like...

HS: Sorry, I tell a lie. I do remember a woman coming in at one stage and she just came in. And we are sitting round in a circle. She might have been a midwife. She came in and she was just coming round really. But it was just like a generalised talk.

OD: Right, so there was no physical...

HS: And I remember her just feeling round the bump and stuff and saying: “Oh, that’s a big baby you have in there”, or whatever. And, he was a big baby, but that’s just the only time and that was just like, I don’t know whether she was brought in just to have a general pep talk maybe. But there was no physical examination or whatever, as such.

OD: To be nineteen and told “oh, that’s a big baby”, when you don’t really know what’s going to happen.

HS: How am I going to get him out? [laughs]

OD: It must be scary. So you’ve talked a little bit about, like, the kind of psychological way in which they kind of made you feel shamed or they made you feel small. And was there anything else that you would want to add to that about kind of whether or not you felt any other kind of ...?

HS: It’s just the whole isolation of everything and the whole secrecy and it’s, you know, you were never sat down and asked, you know, how you felt. You know, you were never told there was another option. You know, options weren’t discussed. It was just literally ... It’s as if you were kidnapped in the middle of the night, dumped in a home for a period of time till a baby was born. And I’m being really blatantly honest with you. And I don’t frill things up, maybe, I’m very black and white, and it’s maybe because of that, the way I’ve had to live my life. But it’s just basically was a function, somebody else in the peripheral was carrying out the paperwork, discussions, phone calls or whatever. I was literally just take in, carried out a function. The end result of that was there was a baby there, wherever that baby was going or whoever was buying it or whatever the case may be. I don’t know, and it was never discussed.

I think the thinking behind it was the least discussion we have, the easier it's going to be for us to do whatever we need to do. Don't give them an option, because then that might stop them doing what they're here to do. Where I just bucked the trend.

OD: And if you have no agency, then signing's easy because you don't know what you're signing.

HS: This is it.

OD: I mean that's really a key point, I think is this idea that...

HS: And my parents never said to me you're going to have to sign away. They obviously had it all sorted. And I suppose whenever the baby was born, then I was going to be told that, look we'll go back six weeks later or whatever the case may be. Nobody said there was another option at any stage.

OD: No, but you figured it.

HS: You know.

OD: So you had visitors in that your parents could come once a fortnight or once a week.

HS: Maybe once a fortnight, once a month. Not to the home, they would have taken me out.

OD: And were you allowed to leave whenever, you weren't allowed to leave whenever you wanted?

HS: No, God no.

OD: And was everything locked?

HS: All doors, all everything was locked down, yeah. And you had to be out... well I suppose, the way that they explained it to you was, well you couldn't go out in groups. They were afraid about you getting attacked, you could only go out in twos. But sure, how was a pregnant woman going down the street, like you could have been anybody. You didn't necessarily have, you hadn't got *name of mother and baby home* tattooed on your head like.

OD: And you don't have a uniform or anything.

HS: And you don't have a uniform, no, ordinary clothes like. Yeah.

OD: And you couldn't sort of make friends, it just wasn't easy to make friends because you couldn't talk.

HS: You were cut off from everybody. You weren't allowed to have those open discussions.

OD: Even at night with the cubicles, you couldn't talk over the...

HS: In bed, lights out. And that nun that I told you about with the *identifying physical characteristic redacted*. She used to parade up and down the things. No, no, no talking.

OD: And do you... I mean, what were you scared would happen if you talked?

HS: You just had that fear that you were going to be put out on the street.

OD: Kicked out.

HS. And nowhere to go like, you know.

OD: At your most vulnerable I suppose.

HS: Yeah.

OD: So, you didn't feel particularly rebellious when you were there?

HS: No, you just felt totally vulnerable; totally powerless to do anything. Couldn't make a decision because nobody would talk to you about anything. I felt actually very isolated. I would have spent a lot of time maybe in my room on my own, maybe drawing and stuff like that, you know. And yeah you would have spent maybe in the afternoon times you would have, they would have given you balls of wool or something to knit jumpers, or play Monopoly, or something like that. But again, they would have been pacing the room to hear your conversations and do you know what I mean.

OD: So it would have been quiet?

HS: They were always, and then even if there was a wee hint of a conversation, you would have been pulled into Sister C's office where you were told: "What's the rules? You know you're not allowed to ask those questions." You know. But you were never told what would happen. But you always had that...

OD: And Sister C, was she... you said you didn't see her that often.

HS: Not very much. She spent her time in the office obviously doing paper work, taking the money, driving the home or whatever she was doing. And the only time you would have, if you'd have seen her coming you'd say; "Fuck, Sister C!" Excuse the language. "Sister C's coming!" You knew something big was going down.

OD: So were you scared of her?

HS: Yeah, you kind of... oh, she was bullish like. She was...

OD: Scary?

HS: Yeah.

OD: Ok. How did you cope when you were outside? Did you manage to find it easy to go back into normal life? Obviously you had a baby which makes things difficult anyway.

HS: Yeah.

OD: But was there a sense of like things are different now?

HS: Probably not, no. Well yeah, things would have been different like you wouldn't have, I wouldn't have, I didn't go out for months and months and months. I kind of just stayed at home because you still had that stigma. Like if somebody asked you "we haven't seen you in four or five months. Where were you?" How do you explain that to somebody?

OD: Do you feel like people know? Or were people genuinely unsure?

HS: People genuinely were probably unsure. They probably thought I was going to live with relatives or something. Like you go away and you appear back six months later with a baby. And they're going "right, where was she?" You know, they obviously knew you were pregnant before you left. Maybe people in the town do know. I don't know.

OD: But you were able to go right back to work in the same place?

HS: I went back to work, yeah. And then, but they knew me, you see, before I left. So it was still the same people. I remember the people, the people *employers details redacted* were so good to me when I was pregnant. So good to me. They were better to me than my parents were. They were brilliant. And they would have protected me. Even, they would have encouraged me to come out with them, you know, at night time. "Well come out with us", and you say "I don't really want to." You know, because you're always frightened of somebody coming up and calling you a slag, or calling you a... you know what I mean, you know what people are like. And you always, even now, you still have that element of just being that person, that person that's just beneath everybody else type thing, you know.

OD: So it's had a really long-lasting effect?

HS: And it will have, it will have.

OD: Of course.

HS: I'll never feel any different. I'll always feel that, you know...

OD: So what do you take, what can make you feel better now? Is it your kids, is it working?

HS: Just the fact that I can work and I can support them and I'll damn well make sure that nobody ever leaves them as vulnerable as I was. And I probably do carry a resentment against my mother as well. I don't, I mean I speak to her and, you know, but I'm always good and respectful to my mother or whatever. But she still has that thing with me. And I don't know whether it's because she can't, I don't want to use the word control because that's probably too strong a word, but I think that because I did have a mind of my own and I did do, you know, what she didn't want me to do. And I think maybe, you know, she kind of sort of can't handle that or whatever. But again, she's never discussed it. It's the fact that's it's never been discussed, nobody has ever said...

OD: It must be really hard to get over that?

HS: Yeah, and it seems to be ok just to do it like: "Our *interviewee's name redacted*, she'll be fine, she'll not..." But nobody sees the hurt inside. You know, you can paint a picture, you can gloss it up. But inside, here and up here [HS indicated her heart and her head], it's difficult at times.

OD: Do you think there was an assumption, either in *year of son's birth* or even now, that if you were tough enough to get into that situation...

HS: You were tough enough to deal with it?

OD: You were tough enough to deal with it. Because I think that's really misguided, isn't it? It doesn't take into account a lot of the reasons why women got into this situation in the first place. I mean getting pregnant, obviously first of all involves a man as well. But second of all...

HS: Exactly. Oh, just they walk away scot-free. But look, that's, that will never change. That will always be the way of the world and it always has been the way of the world. That's not going to change anytime soon. But it's just the fact that yes, it was totally, me or the women or whatever, that were taken and scolded and shunned upon and frowned upon and right through their whole life, you'll always have that element within you that always feels I did wrong.

OD: Yeah, of course.

HS: Nobody else did. I did wrong. And you're always like, the people that you most expect to support you were the ones that let you down and that's probably the hardest thing. And I look at my mother sometimes and I listen to the way she talks to people. And she's so materialistic and so herself. Everything's driven, everything's all about her and, you know, she never, she's just, I don't know. I can't even describe her really, you know. But she just...

OD: It sounds very different to the way you've raised, the way you've chosen to be as a mother and...

HS: Maybe that's why, maybe that's why, you know. She's so cold, unapproachable...

OD: It must have been so hard to... I mean to still not talk about it thirty, forty years after. It's just difficult.

HS: And we never will.

OD: No, I suppose not.

HS: Not now we won't, no.

OD: What do you think would happen if you brought it up?

HS: Oh, she would just cut it off dead, yeah. So there's no point.

OD: Do you have any health issues that came from it? I mean you can say certainly psychologically or physically. I mean do you think you were harmed either because of your experience with birth or your experience during labour or your experience while you were pregnant or anything?

HS: I don't really know the answer. Physically I don't think so. Emotionally and psychologically, yes.

OD: Yeah, and that's incredibly understandable because...

HS: Yeah, I deal with it like, you know.

OD: And do you, did you join any of the, I can't remember whether you came through any of the groups. Were you a member of any of the groups?

HS: No.

OD: And if there a reason that you chose not to?

HS: I didn't know they were available.

OD: Oh, ok. Yeah, there's some kind of groups that, we've got some information about them there, but yeah, sort of Birth Mothers for Justice is one, SAVIA is another, it's groups of women who kind of joined, who either were adopted themselves or were in these homes and they kind of function as a support group.

HS: And they're together, yeah.

OD: And I just wondered if there was, if you'd ever sought out anything like that.

HS: No, never. Again because well I didn't know they were there. Maybe if I'd have gone looking for something, I might have discovered them. But...

OD: But you never felt the need to look, interesting.

HS: Again, I'm a very closed shop. A very closed shop. And will very rarely ask somebody for help, very rarely. But that's ingrained from day one. When you're let down at the most important time in your life. And I'm still very like that today, very like that today. And if I asked somebody for help, it's a very rare thing. And if I don't get the help or they put a... making excuses to why, then I never ask a second time.

OD: Yeah. I can understand that.

HS: Never asked a second time.

OD: Well you faced one of the most scary things for a woman on your own. So it would make sense that you trust yourself more than you would trust...

HS: Probably, well that's probably what it is. You probably don't trust somebody else to do the job, not as well as, but I'm always hanging, waiting for that let down. You're always waiting for somebody to let you down. I find it very hard to trust people, very, extremely hard to trust people because you always think people have an ulterior motive. Do you know what I mean? Or there's always waiting on an opportunity to hurt you. But that's my issue, that's, I have to deal with that.

OD: It is. But it's also very understandable. Who is responsible for what happened to you do you think? If you were going to apportion blame to someone.

HS: To somebody.

OD: If you feel that way. It may be that you don't even feel that way.

HS: Well I don't really even, well I don't really feel... I've never actually given it much thought until recently and it's obviously it's raising its head more, maybe psychologically it's raising its head more, even before I contacted you guys as well. You know, I've found myself, now and again, maybe mentioning it to people or whatever. But it's always, it's an issue that's been buried deep and maybe it's because it's become so public now and I feel it's easier maybe to talk about it. Now obviously not to everybody. But I do believe my parents could have given me a choice. They could have sat down and talked about it. They could have given me another option.

OD: Some kind of understanding of what was happening.

HS: Yeah, instead of just saying push it away, brush it under the carpet. Get rid of it, get rid of it. Do you know what I mean?

OD: What do you think about Irish and Northern Irish attitudes? Do you have an issue with the way in which they treated kind of pregnant women in this situation? Do you think there's a state responsibility to kind of address that? Or do you think it's just the religious aspect or...

HS: I think now, I think it would be more like the religious aspect of it. I really do. And I know it's ok the convent saying that yeah, we were the only ones that came in and took those babies and all that sort of stuff, but I really don't think, I clearly think it's down to, I think it's really heavily laden with the religious aspect of things.

OD: Yeah, of course.

HS: It's like there's less religious pressure now and people are able to work with these things. People are getting pregnant every flipping day and we're able to deal with it. Do you know what I mean? They're going out there, yes the state helps them out financially and stuff. I never had that. Hope to God, touch wood that I'll never need it, that I'm able to raise the two myself. I don't want anybody's pity. I don't want anybody's money. I asked for it once and never got it. So I won't ask again for it.

OD: Well I think when you've got your children to, what thirty...

HS: He's *son's age redacted*.

OD: *Age of HS's son and daughter redacted*, you've done a really good job.

HS: But it's not over yet.

OD: No.

HS: It's not over yet.

OD: Get them through uni.

HS: Get them through uni and make the two of them have a roof over their head.

OD: Of course.

HS: And that's it. You know. But it's the religion, the religion played a big part in it and I think it was the fear of the Catholic Church that made so many Catholic families push their daughters in that direction.

OD: Yeah, of course.

HS: I really do. I really do.

OD: And perhaps maybe there's a responsibility then for, if the state needs to address this through an inquiry like this, you know, would you ask them to look at the involvement of religion? Or would you ask them to apologise for their role in it? What would you want from an inquiry like this?

HS: But who needs to apologise for it? Like they need to take, you know, that so many are looking for apologies and so many people are looking to lay blame and stuff like that. They need to, it's a difficult one because I talked through this in my own head and stuff like that. Parents need to take responsibility. You know, at the end of the day, my parents could have sat down and said: "Look, you've got yourself into a situation. What do you want to do?" Was there enough knowledge then as to the fact that there is another option? Or was it just the easy option to push it into a home and let them sell babies or whatever they were doing? I don't know what they were doing. They certainly didn't sell mine, I took mine home. I don't care who that offends or who that upsets and the pity of it is that more mothers weren't strong enough and weren't able to do that. I was prepared to take him and live on the streets. That's how determined I was. I'm not the same as every other person. I think there's a whole lot of people who have to take responsibility. I think parents - and every house isn't the same. Maybe it wasn't an option to keep a baby and maybe it was a better thing to have a baby adopted. There should have been clearer options. There should have been clearer rules there. The discussion should have been had. And yes, okay the state institutions, the government, everybody else was involved. Everybody is answerable in some measure to the situation.

OD: Absolutely.

HS: There's no one individual group of people or no one individual person. I have to take responsibility for the fact that I got pregnant in the first place.

OD: Yeah, but...

HS: I have to take responsibility for that. But it happens. The other person who was involved with me also has to take responsibility for that. That didn't happen. Do you know what I mean? So you've got to whole group of people out there trying to blame, the abuse and stuff that happened is inexcusable, inexcusable. Especially for vulnerable women that were going in, so vulnerable, at a time in their life carrying babies, pregnant with babies. Like that's inexcusable. But again like, there's a whole lot of people who have to take responsibility for it, you know.

OD: So out of an inquiry like this then, you'd like, what would you most like? So, you know, almost sort of, why did you want to contribute to it? What do you want to happen?

HS: Well I just wanted to make people aware of what happened in the homes. As I said, ours probably wasn't the worst. There are worse stories out there. But again, it's the options people, people weren't, it wasn't discussed. Like I was literally whisked from my home into the doctors for my first appointment and almost the next week I was stuck in a home somewhere without anybody discussing what was going on. The fear of being pregnant in the first place, having to hide it for six months. And then all of a sudden, whenever somebody else in your family, your auntie tells your mother, you're sitting about waiting for your father to come in to see whether you're allowed to come home or not. That's what my mother said to me. She come into work and says to me:

"Is it true? I've just heard. Your auntie *name deleted* just told me you're pregnant. Is that the truth?"

"Yes, it is".

"Well you'll have to stay here. Don't come home till I have a word with your father and see what your father says".

So I'm sitting in work till eight o'clock at night waiting to see if I have a home to go to. It's that, sitting there not knowing. What I am doing here? What am I going to do next?

OD: So every stage of it?

HS: Oh Jesus, it was terrible. And then at that you're taken out the road and then the next thing you're away in a home. Nobody talks to you, like nobody talked. And those girls were probably the same, you know, rushed out of their homes, pushed into a convent somewhere, cut off from the outside world: no phone calls, no friends, no people coming in, you're not allowed to go out and visit people, your time's restricted, you can go down the street on a Tuesday or a Thursday, you don't go out the rest of the week. You can go on a Wednesday to the Post Office at the top of the road because we need our money. So you can come back and when you've given us your money, if we feel generous we'll give you three pound back and that'll do you for the next two weeks to get yourself the fresh fruit and veg that you're supposed to be eating. Or to get yourself your toiletries that you need. And if you're feeling sick or you're feeling lonely or, you know, maybe you have some wee medical thing that you're afraid to tell them because it's not serious enough to get a doctor in and deal with it.

OD: So you wouldn't... I mean something like heartburn or, you know, you wouldn't...

HS: "Don't ask those silly questions" [indicating how she felt the nuns would answer that]. No, deal with it like. You didn't know what it was and you had no

access to phones or internet or any of that stuff. You didn't know what it looked liked.

OD: And if no one explains to you...

HS: And if no one explains to you, you don't know what you're feeling, you know. There was just so many unanswered questions, you know.

OD: Is there anything else you'd like to add. I just wondered if there's anything you wanted to be included.

HS: I'll probably think of loads of things when I get home now and, you know, because I've never actually, this is the first time in *number redacted* years, that I've actually even discussed this with anybody openly.

OD: How does it feel?

HS: It's a bit of a relief, I think. Probably the fact that you're, people, somebody's taking it seriously. Somebody's thinking like this is a serious thing that happened and wasn't nice, you know, and it is something that you shouldn't have to continue feeling ashamed about for the rest of your life. You probably will. That element of shame will never go back because it's so deeply ingrained. But yeah, and the people that are out there that need the help the most, need the help, give it to them. And you see the whole carry on with Stormont and all the rest, whatever's going on, there are people out there that genuinely need help to get over this. I'm probably tougher than the average bear, but, you know, sometimes, sometimes I'm not, but who can deal with it. But there's women out there that are really struggling with this.

OD: Yeah absolutely.

HS: And if the financial help is there to help them with psychologists or whatever help can be offered, give it to them. That's the least you could do. You know, you can't take back thirty-odd years. You can't change it. It's there, but make the best of whatever's left.

OD: If you have the ability to offer those kinds of services, that's something you would like to see them do?

HS: Absolutely, give it to those girls that need it and make sure going forward that those place are either not open, or if they're open... and look don't get me wrong because there are people that maybe have nowhere else to go, only places like that. But if there are places like that that will take those girls in, shut them down. If you can't provide a service that's going to help those girls, shut them down. Shut them down, like, if they're not already shut, you know. God has his own way of dealing with that. So that's the way I believe, you know.

OD: Absolutely.

HS: I'm not an overly religious person, but there has to be somebody that...

OD: Is able to...

HS: Is able to oversee the whole thing, you know. You just have to keep an open mind to things. I'm one of the lucky ones I think.

OD: Well I can just say thank you so much.

HS: Thank you for listening to me.

OD: No, I mean it's really, I think it's really... your story is very, very interesting and will make a very interesting addition to kind of the group. But more than that, I think if people can talk about it so openly the way you've done, that's such a valuable thing to have. So I'm going to switch the recorders off if you're happy.

END OF INTERVIEW

